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Bill Watrous

Trombonist Bill Watrous was born in Middletown, Connecticut on June 8, 1939. Early playing experience included work with local Dixieland bands and study with Herbie Nichols during his military service. Bill worked in Kai Winding's group from 1962-67 and freelanced around New York with Quincy Jones, Maynard Ferguson and as a member of "The Merv Griffin Show" band. He led the Manhattan Wildlife Refuge big band in the mid-70s and later moved to the west coast where he continued to perform in jazz settings and in the film studios. His prodigious technique and musicality has made him the leading trombonist of his generation and he frequently shares his expertise in educational settings across the country.

Bill was interviewed in Clinton, NY on March 26, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming today at Hamilton College for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm absolutely thrilled to have Bill Watrous with me today, who I can personally testify is one hell of a trombone player.

BW: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Welcome. It's been a great pleasure doing some playing with you, and having your name with the jazz festival tomorrow is a real plus. So you are a son of a trombone player I read.

BW: Yeah, Ralph Watrous played with a lot of territory bands and regional bands and he did vaudeville. He went to New York and played with the WMCA studio band for a while. Nothing too exciting.

MR: Was it a full time thing for him, or kind of off and on?

BW: At that time it was, yeah. It was basically all he had, you know, what he did. It was what he wanted to do with his life you know, and of course the Depression came around and took him out. It took a lot of people out. And my dad would have been smart if he'd have stayed in it. But something happened. I think he met my mom and got married and realized he had to make a living and he sort of stepped out of the business. There were other little political factors that sort of dictated his disappearance so to speak.

MR: It seems like entertainment didn't suffer during the Depression years as much as a lot of businesses.

BW: It's about the only thing that didn't suffer much.

MR: And I'm curious, you mention territory bands. This is the east coast, right? Connecticut?

BW: Well he was mainly functioning in Cincinnati at the time.

MR: Usually when I hear the term "territory bands" I think of the midwest for some reason, but I guess anybody could have a territory.

BW: Yeah well it was midwest. I mean territorial bands were everywhere. You know you see them and we hear about them.

MR: How did your music experience in the public school system affect you? Was it okay or did you kind of —

BW: It was okay. I remember in grammar school there was a little old, Earl Barry, he was a violin player actually. A nice little old man with a moustache and we had a silly little band made up of around 19 violins, 4 or 5 mandolins, 3 or 4 or 5 maybe accordions, a bunch of metal clarinets, and a drummer and me. And that was what the band was. And oddly enough I actually wrote in the seventh grade, I wrote the "Niantic School March," which we played of course. I wrote it out and he transcribed it the way he thought I meant it you know. I was rather — you know, what he did wasn't exactly what I had in mind, but we played it that way anyway. Because I hadn't notated it correctly. Musically and melodically it was right. But for some reason there were things that were notated and I actually quoted the final strain to "El Capitan" by Sousa in this thing and not ever having thought about it. He excised that.

MR: Hey, he might have saved you from getting arrested.

BW: No in those days, most of those marches were in the public domain anyway, except for those that are still published. That one might still be under warranty.

MR: Were you doing piano and stuff at that time?

BW: No.

MR: I'm always curious how a person who plays a single note instrument hears enough harmony and stuff to write a chart.

BW: Well you know what's surprising is I always, from day one, was aware of the bass notes and harmony and notes. And I could always, for instance, go along with the radio and sing kind of harmony notes that worked. Automatically. Because I went that way, it was just the way of what — I guess I was born to hear them. To this day I'm not a major keyboard player or anything, but when I sit down and write a composition, I just write out the parts. I just write all the parts out.

MR: You can hear it.

BW: Um hum. Yeah. I wrote my concerto that way. I wrote a "Concerto for Wind Ensemble and Trombone." I just sat on the bed and wrote out my solo part, flat out, all the way to the end, and then indicated on the score what I wanted my orchestrator to do. I just sent it over to him and let him do it.

MR: That's wild. Yeah. Did you like the way he orchestrated it?

BW: Oh it was exactly what I had in mind.

MR: Cool.

BW: Yeah. It actually comes off sounding a little like Edward Elgar, the first movement.

MR: Wow. Do you get to play that at all anymore?

BW: Once in a while, yeah.

MR: Well did your father, was he pleased that you took up the trombone? Did he want you to?

BW: Monk, I suppose he was initially, because he had all kinds of trombones laying around the house and I would come home from school and I would get them out and I'd put a Reynolds bell on an old slide, and a Conn bell on a King slide and something else on something else and he'd come home and find peanut butter and Bosco all over everything, right? And you know, Bosco, when it dries, it has to be chiseled off like black cement.

MR: Not the best thing for a smooth slide.

BW: No. He was understanding about it. He never really gave me much attitude about it. And so I just simply developed on my own. I can't recall him taking any active part except to criticize, that was his role, was to be critical. "Oh your mouthpiece isn't positioned properly" blah-blah-blah-blah. "You're using too much pressure" or this, that and the other thing, the little things, and I used to watch how he would keep his corners down when he played, and how gracefully he moved the slide. There weren't any jerky movements at all when he played. So that kind of set—

MR: Yeah. You know I have this recollection, I was either in college or around then and a bunch of my musician friends were watching a show that you were on. I can't recall what it was. But they had this very close-up thing and like we just were in awe. First of all what you were playing, the range and so forth, but that it seemed to effortless and immovable. No gyrations.

BW: No, I've never allowed those to become a feature, a focal point of my playing. Because I learned early on that the fewer number of moving parts, when it came to this business here, was the most optimum as far as efficiency went. Because I tried it a lot of different ways and if you're really curious and spend a lot of time adjusting what you are doing, and are interested enough, you'll find a way to do it, to get the best results, and that's basically the way I went.

MR: So at what point in your high school or whatever growing up, did you decide or have a feeling that you could make a living as a musician?

BW: I guess I was between my junior and senior year I would say. I got the chance to play — one thing my dad did right, there was a lot of kid bands that were made up in the high school, Policeman's Benevolent Association dances and little quasi-Dixieland bands that

weren't very good. My father blocked me from playing with those. But he made inroads with some older, in their 30s and 40s type players, who had club date bands around the area. And he made sure, he found a way, actually it worked out where there was a girl that really was interested in me, whose father was a great saxophone player. And he played in a lot of bands around. And she prevailed upon him, with of course prodding from my dad, to start using me on some jobs, saying that I knew a lot of tunes. Well he didn't know what I knew at that time, but I really did for some reason or other, probably because I absorbed them early, learned a lot of tunes. And the first time I played a little job with them they were so surprised, he and those other guys that I knew the tunes they were playing, and they just kept me on, and they put me on a lot of the gigs that they played. And consequently I didn't fall into these childish habits that a lot of young players have, of not knowing the form of things, not knowing the proper way to function in an ensemble. That's a lost art.

MR: Why is it a lost art these days? You've got so many music schools now where you can go and learn this craft.

BW: Yeah. But we have all kinds of written music, don't we. We have a lot of big band stuff and it's all written out. Phil Woods waxes poetic on this point. But there are very few schools in which they take the time to teach the craft of playing in a small ensemble, okay. Say one say the size of the one that we recorded with today, or smaller. You know, very few teach the responsibility of functioning in those ensembles. I have a little question and answer game that I play with every clinic group I work for. I say, "okay, I've got a question for you. I have a hundred dollars in my pocket for the person that comes up with the right answer." I says, "anyone here give me, in four words, the primary function that you have to assume in an ensemble." And I'll wait and I'll wait. And some will say, "to play in tune," and I say that's part of it. And some will say, "to blend?" I say, "yeah that's good, that's nice." "To play in time?" "Yeah that's good too." "To get a good sound?" "Yeah." I say, "your primary function is to protect the sound." That is the primary function in any ensemble. And the young people as far as playing together, listen to young combos for example. You'll hear everything wrong there is to hear, in young high school combos, with few exceptions. Every so often some will come along that have spent some time listening to Clifford Brown records, and you'll have somebody that'll come out and play "Joy Spring" okay, and have an idea as to what it goes. But most of them don't do that. They're picking and sort of like flailing out, trying very hard, but flailing very hard out into the open air to try to find something that works, and they're still thinking like a big band instead of like a combo. And this is what happens.

MR: Yeah, in high school they don't get much chance to do a small combo, or how many instructors in high school really know how that goes anyway.

BW: Or have the time, Monk. That's part of the problem. They're put upon to provide a wind ensemble, a symphonic band, a football field band, and possibly a jazz ensemble. And between all of those things, that's about all the time they have see? And though, see we were fortunate, my band director in high school, Dick Benvenuti, took the time to have music theory class, theory one and two, and harmony one and two. And he taught us an awful lot of things about harmony and playing a part and blending and listening carefully. And we would get into theory class, we'd get to bring in different records of different people and play them, and we'd listen to how their sound processes were, and we got to hear them. So that helped us. But we don't have that now.

MR: Well let me get back to your entrance into the professional ranks. New York City?

BW: Actually I started playing professionally up in Connecticut when I was in high school. That's really where I basically started. I started making 25, maybe 50 bucks on the weekend.

MR: That was a lot of money.

BW: Yeah. Because there was a lot of jobs, a lot of dances and little club gigs. And Dixieland of course was hitting the mark pretty heavy up there, and of course I was the only trombone player in New London, Connecticut really, who could play Dixieland. So these guys just took me under their wing and there it was.

MR: Great. That's the best school you can do, right?

BW: Well yeah. Because Dixieland is a prime example of how an instrumentalist has to fill a certain role. For instance the clarinet player plays the obbligato to the trumpet player who is playing the melody. And the trombone player functions somewhere between the bass and another obbligato instrument. He sort of fills in that hole. So your roles are pretty clearly established. And I loved it, and I still love it.

MR: What about the Dixielanders at some of the bands you see that, oh gosh, the straw hats and the suits and so forth. You see a lot of that in California with the Dixieland societies. Are they good players?

BW: Some of them are, yeah.

MR: Yeah?

BW: Yeah. There's different levels of bands. The Abelone Stompers for instance, up in Carmel, were a really good band. Old Jake Stock ran that band, and his son Jackson I believe runs it now, and there's some great players: Fast Eddy Erickson and Jackie Coon and I mean there's some really great players, no question about it. Anybody who has heard Fast Eddy Erickson play the banjo has to admit that this is a serious instrument.

And Jackie Coon is one of the seven wonders of the world and Buddy Jones up there, who used to play with Charlie Parker and played bass on "The Jack Sterling Show" back there in the 50s, they've all got quite a background behind them.

MR: Billy Butterfield and Kai Winding. You got into that?

BW: Yeah. Butterfield came first. I was actually, I had just gotten out of the Navy and actually, no they were sort of interspersed with each other I think, I take that back. I was just about to get discharged from the Navy when my brother and this funky girl that he was dating at the time came down to my house at the Brooklyn Navy Yard and they were all discussing what I was going to do when I got out of the Navy. And I said, "well I could call up Kai Winding and get a job right away." So she says, "go ahead, do it." It was a trick, right? We didn't even have a phone, okay. So I had to go down in the basement down there, and I looked up and called information and found out sure enough Kai Winding lived in Dobbs Ferry, New York, so I called him, and lo and behold got him on the phone. And I said "my name is Bill Watrous and I play the trombone and I'd like to come and play for you sometime." He says, "well unfortunately my ensemble is set right now but of course if you want to come to rehearsal this week we can check you out. We'll be rehearsing Wednesday at Lynn Oliver Studios." So Wednesday came and I put my stuff in my old 1959 Ford convertible which was ready for the bone yard by this time after being in New York for a little bit, and I started heading for 89th and Broadway, and my car died at 87th Street, the battery was just hopeless. So I got out there and huffed and puffed my way up to 89th Street and as I'm going up the stairs I hear the band playing "'Round About Midnight." You know, four trombones, and they were playing it great, I thought oh, man, I don't know if I should even be here. These guys are really super professional, right. But I went up there and I went in and finally they had the four trombones, and they sounded great, and he finally said, "well would you like to sit in and play something?" Of course yeah, I get my horn out, and he said, "well what would you like to play?" I said, "'The Preacher' would be good," because I had heard their recording on Columbia, and I had literally taken the parts off of the album and played it down. So we played this thing, I thought okay, this is my one chance here, to do this thing. And I said well I've got to make it good. So I literally launched into a series of choruses, as if my life had depended on it. And in fact it did. And in fact as I was finishing my last chorus on this I saw Eddie Green the trombone player, actually packing his horn up, leaving. But he didn't know what was to come. Because after a couple of tunes, then they called out something that I hadn't seen. And they found out what a lousy sight reader I was at that time. I couldn't read at all. Nothing. Zip. Zilch. And they all had a discussion in the back room. They says, "listen this guy can't read a note" they said, "what are we

going to do with him?" And Ross Tompkins and Russell George said, "look I don't care if he can read a note or not, he swings like crazy and we can teach him to read." And sure enough, I got hired for the gig and lo and behold a bit at a time I did learn to read music, as we recently found out. And that sort of led to it all.

MR: I'll be darned.

BW: I wound up playing lots of Dixieland music. In between gigs with Winding I was playing with these little bands that we'd play — I used to sub for Cutty Cutshall at Nick's sometimes, and I would play at the Riviera Club. If I had nothing to do I would just go out and play. You know Roswell Rudd and I used to spell each other between the Cinderella Club and the Riviera, all the time we were there. And in those days, Roswell was some kind of player. And by the way, this table may not necessarily be here.

MR: You think it's like fiction in our imagination?

BW: We think it's here. The table thinks it's somewhere else.

MR: That's quite an inside thing.

BW: That's really not fair, we should cut that.

MR: That's right maybe we'll cut that out.

You must have gotten your reading together some if you're going to do studio work.

BW: Oh yeah. Believe me, I did get it together. There was an awful lot of studio work that came up, there was lots of shows that I worked at the Copa Cabana and places like that where people would come in and we just simply had to read. And then the studio work started because I did an album for this producer named Bob Thompson, and Richard Berkey, he was Bobby Darin's conductor, and I sort of lured him to New York, and Richard Berkey wrote an album of stuff. And what happened was I played a solo on "I'll Be Seeing You" behind this orchestra, behind this singer, and it was an absolute smash, really. It turned out really great. And these guys said, "hey, let's let Watrous do a whole album," so they did. They did a whole bunch of nothing but strings, harp, rhythm section and me, called "In Love Again" was the name of it. I mean the cover was embarrassing, really, hair all slicked back and a blue suit and a baby face and the trombone and palm trees in the background. It was really—

MR: You still have a copy I would assume.

BW: Well yeah, I have one, it's sort of unplayable in a way because it's kind of beat now. But what they did was in hiring me they also hired in the string section all of these contractors. Gene Orloff and Manny Green and all the big session contractors in New York who suddenly found out that there was somebody besides Urbie Green in New York. Because Urbie was the king of the hill. And all of a sudden here's somebody else. Well I want to tell you the dates started flooding in from that day forward. I mean I was

doing four and five sessions a day. Jingles and/or record dates and then working at the Copa at night. I was never so busy.

MR: Wow you must have had some endurance going on.

BW: Oh yeah. Oh I always have had that because I've always played correctly. I never bruised my embouchure doing that. I could still be playing now on that stuff. I wasn't tired — my mind was going, but my chops were still there. But that never became an issue. Other stuff became an issue.

MR: Being in New York, was it something eventually that the rat race got to be too much?

BW: No I can't say that.

MR: No?

BW: No, I functioned very well, Monk, in New York. I had a nice apartment up on West 72nd Street with French doors and a big formal dining room and all that stuff, and I wound up buying a Mercedes and storing it in the garage down there for trips on the weekends, and my mom lived up in Connecticut so I was — on the weekends if I didn't have anything I'd drive up there. But there was a lot of work. There was a lot of things. Early on I did subs on "The Ed Sullivan Show" and then of course I played for a while on "The Arthur Godfrey Show" and then there was a lot of things in between, a lot of road trips and gigs with Woody Herman's band for a while. And then "The Merv Griffin Show" started. And in between I did some gigs with Billy Butterfield too which were interesting. He was a fabulous trumpet player. He really was. He was just lyrical and melodic and pretty sounding as any trumpet player I'd ever heard, really. A funny little guy too. But after that came "The Merv Griffin Show." In fact I had to beg Woody to let me off. I actually played prior to that with Quincy Jones' big band which was interesting too. Jerome [Richardson] was on that band.

MR: Was that the band that did the European thing?

BW: Yeah but that was after the European tour. Quincy lost a bundle on that tour and was absolutely adamant that he was never going to have a big band again and do that. Because he said he was never going to lose that money again. But that was fun. But then "The Merv Griffin Show" came around in the mid-60s. And we had a pretty good band, Danny Stiles, the late Danny Stiles and myself and Bill Berry and Richie Kamuca, Roger Cumberton and Dick Hafer and Shelly Gold or Shelly Russell, whatever he chose to be called at that time. And we had Jake Hanna on drums, Jim Hall on guitar and Art Davis on bass and of course Mort Lindsey on piano.

MR: Oh yeah, I remember that name now. Mort Lindsey.

BW: Yeah. And that went on for quite a few years. And during that time a lot of things happened. I actually spent a week with the Basie band at one point during their off-

season. But summertime would come and I would take off. At that time I bought property up in the state of Maine, and I sort of discovered a place in the woods where I could sort of set up a fishing camp and I did that every summer. I would take off from about June 20th and I would take at that time my daughter and my ex-wife now up to Maine to this big house that we bought on the oceanfront, which she still owns, and just take the entire summer off. And sometimes I wouldn't play at all the entire summer, I'd just fish every day and do nothing else. And then I'd come back at the end of the summer and there would be a pile of checks waiting for me at the union from jingles and stuff, residuals and stuff man, and I would get in and there would be eight to ten thousand dollars worth of checks waiting for me, as if I'd been working all summer.

MR: Nice. You got paid to go on vacation.

BW: Those were really relaxed days, although I did worry about the time I was taking off. Because I would take from June all the way to September.

MR: You forget, maybe you're going to be out of the scene too long.

BW: Not so much that but I would think maybe I won't be able to play again. But after a couple of years of doing that and finding out that it was relatively easy to get back in the swing again, it didn't bother me. I couldn't do that now. I could not do that now. I couldn't get away with it.

MR: There must have been some funny moments with Jake Hanna.

BW: He was very — "so many drummers, so little time."

MR: Now you told me about some guy who fell off the scaffolding?

BW: Oh yeah, a guy came falling off the boom, he was the boom operator, and he lost his balance and fell down and bounced all the way down hitting things and finally caught himself in the leg, and Jake goes [scats drums]. He caught him, yeah, he nailed him. The guy broke his leg in three places and Jake was buzzed. "Gee, and I caught him too."

MR: The jazz music certainly was changing a lot in those times. Did you get into what was I guess called avant garde or free jazz at all?

BW: I did for a while. Actually what I got into was a rock group called Eclipse. And in this group was Mike Lawrence, a very, very talented trumpet player and Dean Pratt who was a trumpet player who really wanted to play drums so he played drums, and this guy Allen Govan, who became my lead alto player in my big band after a while, and a bunch of us, and we literally wrote our own material. And it was, and the stuff we played, basically the group was sort of like Frank Zappa was what it was. I mean you talk about out, the solos are really, I mean we took some long — in fact I played on Genya Raven and Ten Wheel Drive for a while prior to this. And then I left her to do some things with this group. And we tried and tried and tried to find a decent lead singer and we never did find

one until we scored a kid named Kim Milford, who became the singer and leader actor in the Rocky Horror Picture Show. He left us to go do that, and then we were in the lurch without a singer, and nothing happened, the group just came unglued, but we were really taking everything out. I mean I don't think any of us played a chord tone in any of the solos that we played. Once in a while I will go way outside. I worked last weekend, I was in Delaware Water Gap, I worked a couple of couple of concerts with this high school band and then I went up into Delaware Water Gap and played with Urbie's kid Jessie on piano, who is wonderful. And a couple of good rhythm section players in this club, the Deerhead Inn, and as the night went on we got progressively more involved until the last tune we played, we played this Bud Powell tune called "Haig and Haig," I mean it sounds like rhythming but it isn't. [scats] It's got rhythm, but we burned the heck out of this thing and then I let Jessie play the first five or six choruses on the thing and he really got into it. He and the rhythm section got into this thing and I said, "okay you want to go there, okay let's go there." And I mean I just absolutely took it everywhere. When I got through playing man, Jessie was looking at me like, a big grin of approval. Because I'm not known for doing that. I basically prefer — I was talking with Wendell Brunious, a fabulous trumpet player, about that, how we have both gone through these stages. And we find that basically our most enjoyable moments come when we're right in the middle of the thing. But I mean I don't have any problems — taking it outside is not difficult, you just have to forget everything and just go where you feel like going, is really what you do.

MR: Do you feel compelled to bring it back in?

BW: I keep it in sight. While I'm doing it I keep it in sight all the time. Because I feel that if you don't do that then you're just B.S.ing everybody. I really believe that. I think that if you're going to play outside, you better damn well know where the inside is while you're doing it and keep it in mind and have at least a smattering of an idea as to where you're coming from. If you're going somewhere, you better have roots. You've got to have them. I think you really do. Yet there's a lot of players that absolutely don't care. They have no roots, I mean there's no anchor anywhere, and they don't want one. You've heard them, you've heard these type of players that just ramble on and they hope for a series of happy accidents. And sometimes you get them.

MR: Is it possible for you to describe to a younger player or even me, what do you think about when you improvise? Is it the chords that are behind you? Are you thinking about what you played six measures ago and where you're going with it? Is it possible to put that into words?

BW: I'm thinking ahead frankly. And what I'm basically doing is I'm thinking counterpoint as I'm going. And I'm listening to the textures that the rhythm section is putting out. I'm listening very carefully to the bass and drums and the piano and trying to get a mattress to bounce on so to speak. And if everything is planned, understandable, that's coming down, then it's not difficult, no problem at all to just close my eyes and go and play. It's the same with Wendell. Both of us played on one of those tunes that you had the other day, when it was not clear who was going to play, and the changes weren't necessarily—

MR: I was blown away by that.

BW: Both of us just closed our eyes and just went with it. See if you blunder ahead all the time, you'll never get anything. But if you play a little bit and then stop for a second and listen to where it's going, and go there, there's no problem. That's the secret in that stuff. But people that are trying to have this constant ongoing flow, you can't have an ongoing flow if you don't know where the heck you're going.

MR: To go there, as you say, you need to have spent some years developing your ear.

BW: Oh yeah.

MR: What do you suggest to players to do that?

BW: I would suggest this: I would suggest that they take those Aebersold CDs, okay, and play along and put them on, even if they don't know the tune, and just try and feel their way through there, not getting into a panic but just going where they suggest that you go. And if you listen, if you really honestly listen, and have the ability to listen, of course that has to be developed too, ear training is one major part of this thing, if you can teach them to hear a tone and produce it on their instrument, and then hear a series of tones and do that. And if you equate what you hear with what's coming out of your instrument, it makes it a lot easier. It makes it a much simpler job than if you're just shooting in the dark. You have to close your eyes. I tell a lot of young players, don't have your nose dripping on the paper man, listen to what this thing is doing, close your eyes and get into the capsule and go there. Just let your ear and your feelings sort of take you someplace. It's worth trying. And I always get people to try to do that.

MR: Good advice. Well you must not have taken Quincy Jones' own advice about having your own big band.

BW: No. Oh God. Funny I had sort of a nightmare about that last night.

MR: No kidding.

BW: Yeah. About my big band. That we had showed up to play somewhere and another band was up there playing and my music had been taken off the stand and taken somewhere else, and no one would tell me where it went. And my wife Mary Ann was there and she was angry about the whole thing, and some player that I had borrowed from Frankie

Capp's band, who was going to be sitting in my band, did this thing. It was just a weird, weird dream. I can't imagine why it came, because I haven't even thought about my big band in a while. We play so seldom. We played down at the IAJE this year in Anaheim, and it was a rousing success. They couldn't get all the people in the room that they wanted to get in there to hear it.

MR: Do you have a corps of guys you try to get?

BW: Yeah. I get them. I usually always get them. I don't have a problem. See my band is rather special in the fact that almost everybody gets to blow. It's not like other big bands. I do like Thad and Mel did with the band. Every chart we have, with few exceptions, like the ballads and things, they're my baby. All of the ballad stuff that has to be played, that's what I do. But the stuff that's straight ahead down the middle and open, is usually open for maybe two other soloists besides myself.

MR: You seem to have had a pretty special relationship with Thad Jones. What a guy.

BW: He was wonderful. I was devastated when he left New York number one, and number two when I heard he was sick. I didn't know what to do about it. He wasn't taking any calls or anything. But I found out. Jerome Richardson told me what a special feeling Thad had for me, and I mean he brought me to tears, literally. He gave me a dressing down every so often too, because I wasn't assuming my responsibilities when I played on the band right. I was still flaking off occasionally and trying, you know partying and having a good time instead of taking responsibility for what was my due. I wasn't accepting the responsibility. I was still scared and floundering around a bit. Oh you know, trying to find a way to fit in. Because the band intimidated me, to tell you the truth, it really did. It just went places I never imagined a band could go.

MR: A big band could go.

BW: That's right. And I never forgot that. And when I came off of that band and then started working with Bob Rosengarden's band on "The Dick Cavett Show," and that was a very professionally adept ensemble, I would have to say in the studios that was the most adept ensemble I have ever played with. I mean we had great players on there, I mean and they were just taking no prisoners. The band was so clean and so right, and what Rosengarden would do, bless him, is we would go into rehearsal and the first 45 minutes that we were there he would pull stuff out of the library and we would just blow and get it out of our systems. He would open it up and let guys play. Let Eddie Daniels play, let me play, let Virgil Jones play a little bit, and it was a real learning experience. But it was a blowing experience actually. It gave us a release. It wasn't just a job. We went there and when we went to rehearsal we knew that we were going to play. And when we got through playing then we would go and rehearse the show.

MR: Well he's pretty astute to do something like that.

BW: Yeah. But you see the combination of those things, when I put together my big band in fact I drew on some of the charts from "The Dick Cavett Show" to help me get the ensemble ready and I took some of the stuff from Lew Anderson's band. I had this chart that he'd written for me on "Summer of '42" for me and Danny Stiles to play on and "My One and Only Love" was another feature. So I had those two plus a couple of other things and by the time I turned around I had maybe around I guess 12 or 13 charts that I could play. So we started playing around, playing some gigs with this menial library, it was almost nothing. But the band was exciting enough so that it garnered some attention. And it got John Hammond's attention at Columbia, and Willard Alexander's, and they started thinking, hey now this boy could possibly be another Tommy Dorsey or Benny Goodman here. That's what they were thinking. God bless them both for that. They would come to our gigs, and of course John and Willard came to me and said, "look, we'd like to offer you a Columbia contract." Well I mean I could have gone through the floor right there. So I said wow, what am I going to do? So then I started gathering, I went and got a lawyer and everything, because they had given me this contract. So I went around and I started gathering up whatever charts I could find at that time. And I got a couple of charts from a friend of mine that went to North Texas State "Sweet Georgia Brown, Upside Down" and "Zip City" so I had those two and then I sat down and wrote a chart for myself called "Fourth Floor Walk-Up" which I sat down and wrote. And then I realized that we didn't have enough time and I'd better write another one so I wrote a thing called "Dee Dee" which was just a pretty little bossa nova. And I brought those to the date with me and we went into the session and fortunately — oh and I had a chart by Bill Berry on "Show," Frank Borowski brought in something he'd done for Doc Severinsen that Doc hated, called "Dichotomy." Wayne Andre produced a chart called "Ayo" that Doc Severinsen also — oh no the one that Frank Borowski gave me, Buddy Rich hated. But "Ayo," A-Y-O, the one Wayne Andre did, Doc hated. So I featured Danny on that, and it went — but see I made a critical artistic error, which haunted me the entire time. Willard and John Hammond told me, "listen Herman" — he used to call me Herman, but I found out later that Willard called everybody Herman. He said, "look, Herman, you've got to do some material that everybody knows, like 'Star Dust' or Hoagy Carmichael stuff or nice tunes." He said, "you're doing all original stuff, high energy stuff like Maynard." He said, "we already got a Maynard Ferguson." Well I didn't agree. I was wrong, Monk, I was so far wrong that there was no going back. And we went in and we put out the album and it got some real acclaim. Sales it didn't really get a lot of, it just did okay, with a lot of the young people bought it. And I called it the Manhattan Wildlife Refuge, thinking

that some of the rock & roll lovers would buy the album just by the title alone, which they didn't do of course, it didn't fool anybody. But we put that on the fire and went around. And oddly enough it made enough noise so that all of a sudden I wound up winning a *Down Beat* poll that year and every other year for the next seven years, just on the strength of that alone, which tells you something about those polls. It's basically a popularity contest. Because I play better now than I did back then and I don't think I'm even on the — I haven't even looked. I don't bother anymore. I find that that's basically not conducive to anything. You have to go about the business of performing and taking care of your craft and not worrying about what people are thinking. But that's how that came about. And then the sequel to the album came out, a thing called "Tiger of San Pedro." On this one I broke down and did an old tune called "Somewhere Along the Way," as a bossa nova. I still didn't have one single ballad on there, which was my stock and trade. And in later years I found out, hey you know I can do this and I should do this. But I didn't, and that was a critical mistake on my part, and it frankly cost me my contract. Because I could have reached out not only to these young kids but to an older crowd too. But they didn't pick up on it. They didn't want to know about this. I could have and should have reached out for the masses that way and I didn't do it.

MR: So sometimes the producers and so forth know what they're talking about.

BW: Sometimes they know what they're talking about. I must say that it took me years to learn that lesson and I've finally gotten over that hump. I now know what the people really want to hear. That's why I'm singing now. I'm into this Chet Baker project and I'm trying to gather some investors to help me come up with 27 thousand bucks so that I can go in there and do this tribute to Chet Baker where I will sing all of his tunes. Jerome was kidding me about it the other day but I'm dead serious about it. I could do it. I know I can do it. I'll play on them and do all this stuff.

MR: Best of luck with that.

BW: Hey, I'm going to need it. But it'll be easy. I don't even look upon it as a challenge. It will be like falling off a log. Because I've been singing for years, I just haven't really pushed it. Sue Rainey pushed me into it. She said, she got me to sing with her on a gig. She said, "why aren't you doing this, you're wonderful, do it." And I took that and I said, "okay, Sue, if people throw tomatoes at me I'm going to blame you okay." And she laughed but she's one of the greatest things since sliced bread, that chick. Have you heard her?

MR: No. I've seen her name around quite a bit.

BW: She's so good, and so nice. And she's one of the rarities in our business, you know, an unspoiled female.

MR: Yeah. Singers can be a whole trip, huh?

BW: Oh, a piece of work.

MR: Talk about insecurity.

BW: Good Lord. That's why they used to make them ride in the back of the bus.

MR: Hope the fumes get to them.

BW: No they taught them humility in those days. They don't have it anymore. There's no humility see. They run the show now and we ride in the back of the bus.

MR: Well listen, what took you from one coast to the other?

BW: I met a girl that I loved, and still do, Mary Ann. In fact she's the person that sent the mailer out to you. She's 17 years younger than me and she's very pretty and very cute and very tiny and still looks the same way she did when I met her back in 1976, when I first met her. And she hasn't changed. And that's weird. She really hasn't. She's got the same shape she had back then, same cute little face and blue eyes and pointed nose and everything's intact.

MR: Well she obviously helps you run your business.

BW: She does. If she worked harder at it I'd be even busier. She does it and then sort of gets out of the way. But she's got her hands full with my son Jason, you know. 15 going on 40.

MR: Or 15 going on 11, depends on —

BW: Oh yeah that too. Yeah that's more like it. He's very immature this kid. But he's so big and strong that if he ever finds how great he is at baseball he will start taking it very seriously. Because we've started to show him that there's a lot of money in this, and see money excites him. And that's a kind of a dumb way to get someone involved. I never got into music for the money. I never thought about it. To me it was always for the glory, honest to God, for the glory of playing music, where it all began. To me that was a very honorable thing and a fabulously exciting thing to do, to get up with a great band and play. I thought that everybody liked and admired that situation.

MR: There was enough guys around who felt that way I guess.

BW: Yeah, to make you want to go there.

MR: Was the west coast music scene a totally different—

BW: Different, but you see New York was already in a state of flux at that point. It was — studios were closing down left and right in favor of synthesizers, and everything was moving toward motion pictures and T.V. And Patrick Williams had called me up and said look, because I was looking for an excuse to go out there, because I had just met Mary Ann. I took a tour and I played Donte's out there in Los Angeles and I met this gorgeous creature, and I threw away my black book and I said this is it, this I've gotta have. And

when I called him and I got an affirmative response from him that was all the excuse I needed to go out, because I immediately went out there and I started working for Mary Ann Kline, the Klines, and I started doing all of Pat's shows, with Tony Randall and Mary Tyler Moore and Rhoda and the Lou Grant Show and Charlie's Angels. All these, oh and Fantasy Island. So I had all of those shows I was doing each week. This was before they went and had the strike and then they of course changed the law, the rules of the union, which meant they didn't have to score a new show every week. The stupid union gave them the right to use a library. And to this day, I was talking with Pat Williams the other day, well it's all changed now. That's all gone. In 1990 it sort of dried up totally and was gone. Now the only thing that uses orchestras is motion pictures. And I never really cracked that berry because all of the composers that were doing motion pictures worked with this one, odious female contractor who runs the entire show. Runs everything. And she doesn't want any stars. She just wants Indians. No chiefs.

MR: Why did the union do what sounds like a pretty stupid thing to do?

BW: Why do unions do everything? They get paid off. Sure. Major payoff. Very, very unfortunate.

MR: So it's the 90s and what's the state of jazz?

BW: The state of jazz is always going to be, see the beauty of jazz Monk, and you know this too, so I'm not telling you anything you don't know, jazz will always be there. The state of jazz is that it will always be there. It will never leave you see. Because jazz has been there for a century all right? It's been there for a long time and it doesn't go away. And you know why it doesn't go away? Because it's great music. Because truly great and gifted musicians made it happen from the beginning of time, and they don't fade away like your rock groups disappear and go off into the distance. They come and go.

MR: Yeah, there's some longevity there.

BW: Oh boy, isn't that true.

MR: Okay. Here's a hard question. Can you think, in all the T.V. shows or whatever, some of the most ridiculous things you've seen happen on stage or in the band or—

BW: Well I was involved in a lot of them I'll tell you. There was a show on T.V. years ago called "The Gong Show." Remember? With Chuck Barris? Well I at that time was fooling around with digeridoo sounds on my instrument. And I could literally sort of talk syllables and words. And I got so that I could recite the Pledge of Allegiance, and I was playing, right? I can't do it anymore for some reason. But I was doing something for Milton DeLugg, who was the leader, and I did it and he fell down laughing. He said you've got to come and do that for Chuckie. So I come over to NBC and here's all of these bald headed people in diapers and strange old ladies in tutus, and the strangest,

most amazing freaks you ever saw, and I went and did this thing for Chuck Barris. Well Chuck spit out his orange and he was eating. He said, "you've got to do this." So they rented me a California State Highway Patrolman uniform, and they gave me a name, Frederick Plumducker. Officer Freddie Plumducker, honest to God, and they put me on this show. And what happened was at rehearsal, Joe Howard, the trombone player on the show didn't know me when I came out, and he got laughing so hard that I couldn't do my bit. And finally after rehearsal I went over to Joe and I said, "Joe, it's me, Watrous. Watrous." I thought it'd be something. I says, "whatever you do, don't do that on the show, if you can take a tranquilizer or something, do it, because I want to get through this thing." So I went out there and the show is done in scenic downtown Burbank, and it's the home of all of the right wing extremist groups. And they took offense. Because they put an American flag on either side of me when I went on in my highway patrol uniform and started this thing. And they started hooting and hollering and of course Jaye P. Morgan got up and gonged me and got me off of there, mercifully. And I luckily got out. They were, "hey you don't like this country, go back to Russia you commie pig." I mean they're yelling at me and I'm on the stage, right? So my wife was with me and I said, "honey, let's get out of here before this show gets out, because if these people see me, I'm dead meat." We just got out of there with our skin.

MR: Holy cow.

BW: I mean you'd do anything — in those days anything could have happened to you. I hear they're going to revive the show again.

MR: Hey, it's a classic.

BW: Oh God, it was terrible.

MR: And you were in the pit?

BW: No I wasn't. They put me on as a guest.

MR: Oh okay, because he heard you do that.

BW: Yeah. Hysterical.

MR: Wow, that's a shame you can't do that anymore.

BW: Well it really messes up my chops to do it, really.

MR: I've heard you doing some singing.

BW: Oh yeah, I've done multiphonics.

MR: Is it possible to get a third note?

BW: Yeah you get a third note.

MR: You get a third note?

BW: You actually get an overtone on it. You play one and sing one and you get an overtone. Maybe I'll demonstrate that in my clinic tomorrow as a matter of fact.

MR: And then next Monday all the kids in the trombone section will go [scats].

BW: Oh yeah, they'll get terrible sounds, they'll be really bugging their band director.

MR: What's a typical month like for you these days?

BW: Depends. Now during this season it's every weekend away okay? I've been out now, I've had exactly six days at home in the month of March already. In the month of February it wasn't much better. It really cuts into my fishing time.

MR: Everyone's got to make sacrifices.

BW: Yeah.

MR: Do you still take some time off during the summer to do that?

BW: I have to, it's forced, because my business slows down dreadfully, and it hurts too. Because we have to cut down our expenses during the summer because I've got nothing to fall back on.

MR: It's pretty school-oriented work then?

BW: Very much.

MR: I mean if you, how far are you — you're around L.A. where you live, on the outskirts?

BW: Yeah we're up in the hills outside, around the corner from Burbank, in Shadow Hills.

MR: Well if you want to play a jazz gig in L.A. —

BW: Oh and make a hundred dollars a night? That's about all. So I do a little of that, I don't do a lot. I play on occasion just to keep my hand in the fire.

MR: Right. Did you ever think of writing books about trombone playing?

BW: I wrote one called *Trombonisms*, it's out and available on Carl Fischer. I thought of doing some more stuff. I'm playing with the idea, bashing a few things around.

MR: Yeah? How about taking a big band to Europe?

BW: Oh, over my dead body. If somebody comes up with the right amount of money and a guarantee, I could do that. I almost got to take the band to Japan last year, but it fell through, the economy went down.

MR: Oh yeah. We didn't really talk about maybe just a few of your influences, on the trombone, besides your father. You mentioned a couple of influences, Lou McGarrity or did you sub for him?

BW: I subbed for Cutty Cutshall, that's who I subbed for, but I knew Lou and Lou was a wonderful trombone player. Vic Dickinson was one of my favs at that time, and Trummy Young I loved. Of course Urbie Green and J.J., to say nothing of Frankie Rosolino and Carl, Carl Fontana frankly for me is my all together hands down favorite of them all. I don't think there's anyone today on the scene that is a match for Carl Fontana. He is incredible. Absolutely. Great trombone player.

MR: Okay, so I don't usually ask this question, but if you tried to be real honest about where you fit in the list of trombone players—

BW: You mean the chain of command, right?

MR: Yeah, thank you. Where do you put yourself?

BW: I will relate to you what I've been told by people like Wayne Andre and others. I'm sort of a, if you look down the list of modern trombone players you've got firstly let's start for instance with J.J. for instance and Curtis Fuller and Slide Hampton. Okay, which are icons amongst themselves, and then Jimmy Cleveland sort of falls in the slot there. And then we look at Frankie Rosolino and Urbie and Carl. And I sort of fall in there sort of after those guys somewhere. I'm sort of a, I would say people consider me a kind of a cross between Urbie and Fontana somehow. I mean I've heard this, this is what other people, you're better off sort of quoting what other people are saying rather than try describe yourself. We're the hardest at describing ourselves. But that's the story that I get from people who talk to me about it. They sort of find me in that slot somewhere. And then of course it moves on from there, you know to all today's young players. But today the young players that you see coming up today are not on the level with guys like Fontana and Urbie and Rosolino under any circumstances, or J.J. either. They just aren't. They can't be. That backlog is not there, that track record will never be matched. It can't be. It's unfortunate but it's true. And the opportunities for advancement and development and becoming famous and all that silly stuff is just not there anymore. The road bands are all gone. And sessions. When you go to a session, a session is not like it used to be anymore, it's a whole different entity entirely. Weird.

MR: What kind of music do you like to listen to at home?

BW: You want to really know?

MR: Yes.

BW: Classical.

MR: Well that doesn't surprise me.

BW: I listen to — right now I'm delving into Sir Edward Elgar right now, all of his oratorios, his symphonies, his orchestral works, his concertos. His oratorios, his choral works are incredible. And at the moment I'm reading this book about the life of Mozart, which is written by Madard Sullivan, which is a tremendous undertaking. I mean the book is this thick of tiny small print, which at the age of 60 I find I can still read without assistance, I'm lucky that way.

MR: Great story I'll bet.

BW: Oh it's incredible. The stuff that's in here, you realize you know when you read all of the other accounts of Mozart's life, he wasn't all in that poverty area, he was treated like a

nobleman when he traveled all over Europe, I mean years of course he was attached to the Archbishop in Salzburg's court, but he was given leave with his father to travel all over to all of the cities of Europe and made really copious sums of money for his tremendous feats of music. I mean the guy was writing masses and symphonies at the age of nine, and composing at the age of four and five, I mean it was just phenomenal what we know about this man. And as he got along, I'm up to around page 100 in the book and I have not reached the point where he is twelve years old and he's starting to feel his oats a little bit and he's not going to want his father traveling with him all the time, and he's going to start falling in love, and I snuck ahead and looked in the book and there's some really very, very X-rated stuff in some of his letters to some of the women that he loved, which will absolutely embarrass you. I mean it's incredible the stuff that he thought about and wrote.

MR: Wow. Well the passion came out in his music too.

BW: Oh sure it did, yeah.

MR: Well listen, this has been a real hoot talking to you.

BW: Oh I've loved it. I've loved this entire experience of coming here and playing.

MR: Well good. I hope you can say that tomorrow after dealing with the kids.

BW: Oh, I do that all the time. They need to be dealt with. They need to be talked to and helped out because they're trying, Jesus, they're trying to play music, Monk. They're young kids and they're scared to death some of them, and they're trying to play music. Somebody somewhere along the line has given them the idea that this is something that they should do, and they're trying to do it and some of them have got great band directors that are helpful, and some of them have got band directors that maybe aren't so helpful. And some are fallen by the wayside and not getting what they need, which I think is a travesty frankly. The number of really great band directors who can truly give these kids what they need is I would say in the minority. I'd say 20 percent of the band directors that I see and deal with really know what they're doing. The rest of them need help. Some are marginal, some are adequate, and some of those that are great are really great, they are really something else. And their band reflects what they're doing. That's what I see in working with these kids, and boy if I can give them anything at all, more power to them.

MR: All right. Well best of luck to you in the future, and I'm sure we'll cross paths again.

BW: Monk, I honestly and truly hope this isn't the last time that we get together, because I've taken a sincere liking to you as a person and as a musician.

MR: Thank you.

BW: I believe in what you're doing and I just like anybody else that's called Monk.

MR: Isn't that something?

BW: Because my wife calls me Monk.

MR: We must be all right guys you know that.

BW: It can't be terrible.

MR: I think so. Thank you very much.

BW: Thank you very much, Monk.